THE AYUSHMAN BHARAT FAMILY PLAYBOOK

2026-27

How every Indian family can actually use the Rs. 5 lakh government health cover - including the new card for everyone aged 70 and above, with no income limit.

Digital Edition

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Read this first

Ayushman Bharat is the largest publicly funded health scheme in the world, and it belongs to you if you qualify. Yet most families only meet it in a panic - a parent is admitted, someone at the hospital counter asks for an "Ayushman card", and nobody at home is sure whether the family has one, whether it is active, or whether the bill will be covered. This playbook exists to remove that panic.

It is written in plain English, for real households: the son who manages his parents' paperwork, the daughter who is the first person in the family to own a smartphone, the senior who wants to understand the card named after them. Every fact here is drawn from official sources - the National Health Authority (NHA), the Pradhan Mantri Jan Arogya Yojana (PM-JAY) portal, Press Information Bureau releases and government guidelines - with figures dated so you know how fresh they are.

This is a guide to understanding and using a government scheme. It is not a substitute for the scheme's own portal, and scheme rules can change. Where a number or a step matters for a decision, confirm it on the official portal or helpline (14555) before you act.

What you will be able to do after reading

Check whether your family is eligible under the 2026-27 rules. Generate or download an Ayushman card for yourself, your family, and any member aged 70 or above. Fix the four problems that cause most rejections. Know your rights when a hospital says the card will not work. And use the cover without wasting a rupee of it.

How to use this playbook

- If you are in a hurry, go straight to Part Six. The master checklist, the document kit and the quick-reference card are designed to be printed and stuck on a fridge.
- If your parent is 70 or older, read Chapter 6 and Chapter 12 first. That is the newest and most valuable part of the scheme.
- If you have already been rejected, Part Four is written for exactly that situation.
- Keep the sources page at the back. Every link there is official.

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PART ONE

What this scheme actually is

1. The two halves of Ayushman Bharat

Ayushman Bharat is not one scheme. It is two, working together, and knowing both is what stops a family from queueing at the wrong counter.

The first half is **PM-JAY** - the Pradhan Mantri Jan Arogya Yojana. This is the part that pays hospital bills. It gives a family up to Rs. 5 lakh a year for hospital treatment, and the government pays the hospital directly, so no money leaves your pocket at the counter. This is the scheme behind the "Ayushman card" or "golden card" you hear about.

The second half is the network of **Ayushman Arogya Mandirs** - the clinics upgraded from old sub-centres and primary health centres. These handle everyday care: a fever, a check-up, a blood test, a diabetes review, free essential medicines, and free tele-consultations through the eSanjeevani service. By 2026 there were more than 1.86 lakh such centres across the country.

Why the distinction matters: PM-JAY is **hospitalisation cover**. It is not an everyday-doctor card. If you go to a hospital expecting PM-JAY to pay for a routine consultation, you will be disappointed - not because the scheme failed, but because that is the other half's job. For routine care, your first stop is the Ayushman Arogya Mandir, where the care is free or nearly free.

> **One line to remember**
> Ayushman Arogya Mandirs keep you well. PM-JAY covers you when you are hospitalised. Use them for what each was built to do.

PM-JAY was launched on 23 September 2018 in Ranchi. It is the largest health assurance scheme in the world, funded entirely by the government, with costs shared between the Centre and the states.

2. What the Rs. 5 lakh cover actually pays for

The headline is Rs. 5,00,000 per family per year for secondary and tertiary hospitalisation. Here is what that sentence actually buys.

The cover is a **family floater**. That means the Rs. 5 lakh is one shared wallet for the whole family - one member or all of them can use it, in any combination, up to the limit. There is no cap on family size, age or gender, and pre-existing conditions are covered from the very first day. That last point is unusual: most private policies make you wait two to four years before they cover an existing illness. PM-JAY does not.

When you are admitted at an empanelled hospital, the scheme covers:

- Medical examination, consultation and treatment
- Up to 3 days of pre-hospitalisation expenses (tests and medicines before admission)
- Medicines and medical consumables used during the stay
- ICU and non-ICU services
- Diagnostic and laboratory investigations
- Medical implants where needed
- Accommodation and food services during the hospital stay
- Complications that arise during treatment
- Up to 15 days of post-hospitalisation follow-up care and medicines

The scheme also covers **day-care procedures** - treatments like dialysis or cataract surgery that do not need an overnight stay but still count as hospitalisation. By 2026 the national Health Benefit Package listed about 1,961 procedures across 27 medical specialties, from general medicine and surgery to cardiology and oncology. The whole point is that the money reaches the hospital, not your pocket: at an empanelled hospital the treatment is **cashless at the point of service**.

3. What it does not pay for

Half of all confusion about Ayushman Bharat comes from expecting it to be something it was never designed to be. Here is the honest list of what the Rs. 5 lakh does not cover.

Not covered	What that means in practice
Out-patient (OPD) care	A normal doctor visit, a test, or medicine when you are not admitted. This is what Ayushman Arogya Mandirs are for.
Evaluation-only stays	Being hospitalised purely to run tests, and vitamin or tonic expenses unless part of a certified treatment.
Dental work	Corrective, cosmetic or prosthetic dentistry, fillings, root canals and implants - unless caused by injury, tumour or cyst and needing hospitalisation.
Fertility and IVF	Assisted reproduction and infertility procedures, unless specifically listed in the package master.
Vaccination	Routine immunisation, unless it is part of a national programme.
Cosmetic surgery	Purely aesthetic procedures. Medically necessary surgery that restores function is treated differently.
Sex-change treatment	Hormone therapy or surgery for sex change is excluded here - but transgender persons have a separate card that covers gender-affirming care (see Chapter 5).
Circumcision (under 2)	Excluded unless medically necessary or caused by accident.
Persistent vegetative state	Long-term support in this condition is not a covered package.

Not covered	What that means in practice
Self-injury or suicide	Excluded - though a hospital will treat a life-threatening case until the patient is stable.

A few states run a slightly longer or shorter exclusion list, and organ transplant is handled differently from state to state. When a specific treatment matters, ask the hospital's Ayushman Mitra or call 14555 rather than assuming.

4. The scheme in numbers, 2026

Fresh figures matter, because this scheme has grown fast. These are the latest official numbers, with their dates.

48.51 cr
people hold Ayushman cards, about 33% of India (21 Sep 2026)

Rs. 2.03 lakh cr
of hospital treatment funded since 2018 (21 Sep 2026)

36,000+
empanelled hospitals, about 19,500 public (Feb 2026)

Measure	Latest official figure
Ayushman cards created	43.52 crore (28 Feb 2026)
Vay Vandana cards (70+ seniors)	1.36 crore (21 Sep 2026)
ASHA / Anganwadi worker cards	44.81 lakh (21 Sep 2026)
Hospital admissions authorised	13.25 crore, worth Rs. 2.03 lakh crore (21 Sep 2026)
Treatment in another state	29.05 lakh admissions worth Rs. 8,383.97 crore (30 Jun 2026)
ABHA health IDs	over 97.61 crore (17 Sep 2026)
States / UTs implementing	all 36 (Jul 2026)

One more number is worth holding on to. Out-of-pocket spending - the money families pay themselves - fell from 62.6% of total health spending in 2014-15 to 43.4% in 2022-23, and the government credits schemes like PM-JAY. That is what this scheme is for: stopping a hospital bill from pushing a family into debt.

PART TWO

Who is eligible in 2026-27

5. The five doors into PM-JAY

There is no single "Ayushman eligibility test". There are five separate doors, and a family needs to walk through only one of them. Find yours below.

Door 1 - Rural households on the 2011 deprivation list. If your household was counted in the Socio-Economic and Caste Census (SECC) 2011 and met any one of six deprivation criteria - a single kutcha room, no adult member aged 16-59, a female-headed household with no adult male in that band, a disabled member with no able-bodied adult, an SC/ST household, or a landless household living mainly on manual casual labour - you are automatically eligible.

Door 2 - Urban households in listed occupations. For cities and towns, eligibility runs through 11 occupational categories, including ragpickers, beggars, domestic workers, street vendors and cobblers, construction and other manual workers, sweepers and sanitation workers, home-based workers and tailors, transport workers and drivers, shop workers and waiters, electricians and mechanics, and washermen and chowkidars.

Door 3 - Everyone aged 70 and above. Since 2024, any Indian citizen who is 70 or older qualifies, whatever their income. This is the door most families do not yet know exists, and it is covered in full in the next chapter.

Door 4 - Special categories. Beyond the main list, the scheme reaches Building and Other Construction Workers (and their dependants), road-accident victims under PM-RAHAT, transgender persons under the SMILE initiative, children covered by the PM CARES for Children scheme, waste pickers and sanitation workers under NAMASTE, Particularly Vulnerable Tribal Groups under PM-JANMAN, and about 37 lakh ASHA, Anganwadi worker and Anganwadi helper families.

Door 5 - Your state's own scheme. Most states run a parallel health scheme and have merged it with PM-JAY. These often cover more people, and more money, than the central list alone - see Chapter 7.

The eligibility trick that surprises people

You do not need an income certificate to prove you are poor. Eligibility is checked against government databases (SECC 2011, ration cards, occupational lists, Aadhaar age) - not against a fresh income certificate you have to chase.

6. The 70-plus universal card: the biggest change

On 11 September 2024 the Union Cabinet approved free health cover for every senior citizen aged 70 and above, regardless of income. It was launched on 29 October 2024 as the Ayushman Vay Vandana Card. For millions of middle-class families, this is the single most valuable thing in the scheme.

Read the rules slowly, because they are generous and specific:

- **Who qualifies:** any Indian citizen aged 70 or above. No income limit, no SECC check, no poverty test. Rich or poor, the answer is yes.
- **How age is proved:** through Aadhaar. Aadhaar is the only document needed. If your Aadhaar shows only a year of birth and not a date, the system treats the date of birth as 1 January of the following year.
- **The card is separate:** a distinct Ayushman card is issued to each eligible senior.
- **If the family is already covered:** the senior gets an extra top-up of up to Rs. 5 lakh a year for themselves, which they do not have to share with the younger members of the family.
- **If the family is not otherwise covered:** the senior and their household get a shared Rs. 5 lakh cover, but members below 70 are not included in it.
- **If the senior already has CGHS, ECHS or CAPF cover:** they may choose between the existing scheme and PM-JAY. Seniors on private insurance or ESIC are eligible for PM-JAY as well.

The scale is real: by 21 September 2026, more than 1.36 crore Vay Vandana cards had been created. If there is an elder in your home who is 70 or older, this is the highest-value half-hour of paperwork you can do this year.

7. State schemes that stretch your cover further

PM-JAY is the floor, not always the ceiling. Most states have merged their own health scheme with it, and several offer more cover, or cover more people, than the central scheme alone.

The important rule: in a converged state you do not apply twice. The same card and the same hospitals serve both, and the scheme that applies to you is worked out automatically. What changes is how much you are entitled to and who qualifies.

State	Merged scheme (examples)	What it adds
Rajasthan	Chiranjeevi Yojana	Higher cover with an accident component; near-universal
West Bengal	Swasthya Sathi	Broad universal cover, female-centric card
Maharashtra	MJPJAY (Mahatma Phule Jan Arogya)	Wide eligibility, integrated with PM-JAY
Karnataka	Arogya Karnataka (AB-ArK)	State top-up, strong oncology focus
Tamil Nadu	CMCHIS	Low-income families; extra for major surgeries
Andhra Pradesh	Dr. YSR Aarogyasri	BPL families; camp-based outreach

State	Merged scheme (examples)	What it adds
Gujarat	MA Yojana (Mukhyamantri Amrutum)	BPL and lower middle class
Punjab	Mukh Mantri Sehat Yojana	Upgraded cover in 2026
Uttar Pradesh	MMJAA	State expansion of the central base
Kerala	Karunya Arogya Suraksha Padhathi	Integrated with PM-JAY

Names and amounts differ, and states revise them. Treat the table as a starting point, then confirm your state's exact scheme on its State Health Agency page or by calling 14555. One caveat: a state scheme's extra cover usually applies within that state, while PM-JAY's own Rs. 5 lakh is portable across India.

8. Gig workers and e-Shram: where things stand

If you earn through Swiggy, Zomato, Blinkit, Ola, Uber, Urban Company or similar apps, this chapter is for you - and it needs a careful, honest answer rather than a hopeful one.

The 2025-26 Union Budget announced that one crore gig and platform workers would be brought under Ayushman Bharat, delivered through the government's e-Shram portal. That promise is real and the machinery is being built. But as of July 2026 the health cover itself had **not yet been rolled out** - workers were being registered on e-Shram, and the government had not announced a firm timeline for the benefits to begin.

So the practical advice is this: **register on e-Shram now anyway.** Registration is free, it gives you a Universal Account Number (UAN) that works as a portable identity, it is the gateway the government will use to deliver this cover when it starts, and it already unlocks other benefits such as accident cover under PMSBY. By 14 July 2026, more than 10.65 lakh platform workers had registered. Being early in that queue costs you nothing and positions you for the day the cover goes live.

The legal backdrop also changed: the Code on Social Security, 2020 came into force on 21 November 2025, formally recognising gig and platform workers in Indian law for the first time, with supporting rules notified in May 2026. That is why registration matters - it is how the system will know you exist.

PART THREE

Getting your card

9. The ten-minute preparation

Almost every failed application fails because of a detail that could have been fixed in ten minutes beforehand. Do this first.

1. **Open your Aadhaar and read the name and date of birth exactly as printed.** This is the version the system will trust. If your Aadhaar has an old spelling, fix that before anything else.
2. **Check that a working mobile number is linked to your Aadhaar.** Most eKYC failures are simply an OTP going to a number that is not linked. You can check and update this at an Aadhaar centre or the UIDAI portal.
3. **Find your ration card or family ID.** It links the whole household to one wallet and speeds up approval. In states such as Bihar and Uttar Pradesh a valid ration card can get you an approved card within about 24 hours.
4. **Note your state, district and sub-scheme.** You will select these from dropdowns, and your state may run a merged scheme with a different name.
5. **For a senior aged 70 or above, keep only their Aadhaar ready.** For the Vay Vandana card, Aadhaar is the single document required.

Fix mismatches first, apply second

A name or date-of-birth mismatch between your Aadhaar and the government database is the number one cause of rejection. Correcting it after applying means starting over. Correcting it before takes one visit.

10. Online self-registration, step by step

The whole process can be done from a smartphone. This is the self-service route through the official NHA beneficiary portal.

1. Open the official beneficiary portal at **beneficiary.nha.gov.in**. You can also use the free Ayushman app (Android) or the UMANG app.
2. Choose **Beneficiary** as your login type, enter your mobile number and the captcha, and log in with the OTP.
3. Select your **state**, the **scheme (PM-JAY)** and your **district**.
4. Search for your household using your **Aadhaar number**, your **family ID**, or your **ration card**.

5 Your family members and their card statuses will appear. Look for the member whose status is "Not Generated" or "Pending".

6 Click the **e-KYC** icon and authenticate - by Aadhaar OTP, fingerprint, iris scan or face authentication. Whichever you choose, a second OTP confirms the action.

7 Match the details, capture the photograph, and submit.

8 Wait for approval. An application that matches well is approved automatically; others go to state authorities and typically clear within 24 to 48 hours. Once approved, download the card as a PDF.

One technical detail worth knowing: the system compares your Aadhaar name, year of birth and gender against its records and produces a match score. A gender mismatch scores zero, and anything below about 80% goes for manual approval rather than automatic approval. That is exactly why the ten-minute preparation matters.

11. The offline route: CSC and Ayushman Mitra

If there is no smartphone in the house, or the online route keeps failing, the offline route is just as official and just as free.

Go to any Common Service Centre (CSC), or to the help desk at an empanelled government or private hospital, and ask for the **Ayushman Mitra** - the staff member whose job is to help beneficiaries. Their official title is Pradhan Mantri Arogya Mitra (PMAM). They can search the database, run your eKYC, add family members and print your card on the spot.

Carry: your original Aadhaar, your ration card or family ID, the Aadhaar cards of the family members you want to add, and a mobile phone for OTPs. A passport-size photograph helps but is usually captured live.

> **The fee is always zero**
> Generating, re-generating or correcting an Ayushman card is completely free. There is no enrolment fee. If anyone asks you to pay an agent to "enrol" you, that is a fraud signal - refuse and report it on 14555.

12. The 70-plus card walkthrough

The Ayushman Vay Vandana Card has its own enrolment path, because it is application-based rather than database-based. Here is how a senior gets it.

1 Open **beneficiary.nha.gov.in** or the Ayushman app and log in with a mobile number and OTP.

2 Look for the senior-citizen enrolment banner and start a fresh application (rather than searching an existing family).

3 Enter the senior's **Aadhaar number** and search - the system checks whether they already exist in the PM-JAY database.

4 For a new enrolment, verify the Aadhaar, give consent, and complete the eKYC.

5. Enter both the **Aadhaar OTP** and the **mobile OTP** to proceed.
6. Accept the declaration, complete the KYC details accurately, certify them and submit.
7. On successful eKYC the card becomes available to download. The system checks age from the eKYC data: 70 or above means eligible.
8. Use the **"add member"** option to enrol any other family member who is also 70 or above, so one session covers every senior in the house.

There are three other ways to start the same process: walk into the nearest empanelled hospital and ask the Ayushman Mitra, call the toll-free helpline **14555**, or give a missed call to **1800110770** to get guidance. The enrolment window is open all year - there is no closing date.

13. Adding family members

A card belongs to a household, so adding a missing member is a normal, supported action - not an exception you have to fight for.

1. Log in to the beneficiary portal and search for your family by Aadhaar, family ID or ration card.
2. Open the **Add Family Member** option and authenticate yourself with Aadhaar eKYC.
3. Enter the new member's name, gender, relationship and date of birth, choose the ID type, and upload the supporting document.
4. Submit. State-specific documents may be asked for - a birth or marriage certificate, a PM or CM letter, a ration card, or a government-certified member list.
5. You can do the same thing at a CSC or through an Ayushman Mitra if the online form is awkward.

Note the limits honestly: new family members can be added to existing households, but in the current phase brand-new families that were never in the database cannot usually be added - except through the specific categories (such as construction workers, small traders and farmers) that states allow. If your family is genuinely not in any database, the honest answer is that the 70-plus route or your state scheme may be your real door.

PART FOUR

When it goes wrong

14. "You are not eligible" - what it really means

This message almost never means "you will never be eligible". It usually means one of four things, and each has a different fix.

What the message usually means	What to do
Your family is not in the central beneficiary database	Re-check eligibility at beneficiary.nha.gov.in using Aadhaar, mobile or ration card. If still not found, visit a CSC or Ayushman Mitra - states often hold a larger list than the central one.
Your name or Aadhaar details do not match	See Chapter 15. The fix is usually to correct the Aadhaar record first, then re-apply.
Your family ID or household data is wrong	Go to the District Implementation Unit or State Health Agency with your ration card and Aadhaar, or raise a data-correction complaint at cgrms.nha.gov.in.
A technical eKYC or OTP failure	See Chapter 16. Retry, and use OTP or face authentication if biometrics fail.

The one thing not to do is pay anyone to "fix" it. There is no fee for any of these remedies.

15. Name and Aadhaar mismatch

This is the single most common rejection, and it is caused by spelling, not by eligibility.

The mismatch can come from three places: your name was recorded differently in the 2011 census, your Aadhaar was updated recently, or there is a small spelling variation across your documents. The system then fails its identity match even though you are genuinely entitled.

The fix, in order:

1. Visit an Ayushman Mitra at any empanelled hospital. They can see your beneficiary record and try a biometric or OTP-based verification instead of a name match.
2. If the error is in the Aadhaar record itself, correct the Aadhaar first at a UIDAI Aadhaar Seva Kendra.
3. If the error is in the government database, ask the State Health Agency or District Implementation Unit to correct it, bringing documents that connect you to the original household.
4. If all else fails, raise a formal complaint at cgrms.nha.gov.in - the NHA commits to resolving grievances within 30 days.

16. eKYC and OTP failures

Sometimes the rejection is not about eligibility at all. It is the eKYC step failing on a technicality.

- **OTP not arriving:** your mobile is probably not linked to Aadhaar. Fix the linkage, then retry.
- **Fingerprint not matching:** worn fingerprints are common with age. Ask for OTP or face authentication instead of biometric.
- **Server busy or timed out:** the NHA or UIDAI systems can be under load. Try again after some time.
- **Gender mismatch:** this scores zero in the matching system, so check that the gender on your Aadhaar is correct and consistent.

None of these costs anything to retry, and an Ayushman Mitra can attempt face authentication or an operator OTP as a fallback. Persistence, not payment, is the answer.

17. When a hospital says the card will not work

You have rights here, and they are written into the scheme's design.

An empanelled hospital cannot refuse treatment to a PM-JAY beneficiary for a covered treatment. If you are turned away or told your card "is not accepted", work through these checks:

1. Verify the hospital's empanelment status on the PM-JAY portal. Some hospitals' empanelment lapses or is suspended, and staff may not always know.
2. Check whether your specific treatment is a covered package. Not every procedure is in the list.
3. Ask to speak to the hospital's Ayushman Mitra (PMAM), whose job is exactly this.
4. If the hospital is empanelled and the treatment is covered, ask for the reason in writing.
5. Call **14555** to report a wrongful refusal. Empanelled hospitals that wrongly refuse beneficiaries can face action.

> **In an emergency**
> Empanelled hospitals should admit you and begin treatment; card verification can be completed within about 24 hours of admission. Tell the Ayushman Mitra as soon as you are stable.

18. Complaints and escalation

There is a formal, three-tier grievance system, and it is free to use.

Channel	How to use it
Helpline 14555 / 1800-111-565	Call for eligibility, login issues, hospital problems and to report fraud. This is the national call centre.
Missed call 1800110770	For information about the Ayushman Vay Vandana Card for seniors.

Channel	How to use it
Grievance portal cgrms.nha.gov.in	Register a written complaint online; track its status.
District / State / National committees	Your complaint is routed to the right level. The NHA commits to resolution within 30 days, with a further 30-day right of appeal.

Keep the reference number you receive. A complaint with a number is a complaint that can be followed.

19. The fraud rules: never pay for a free card

Because this scheme involves money and vulnerable people, it attracts fraud. Learn the three rules and you are safe.

- **There is no enrolment fee.** Ever. If an agent, a shop or a website asks for money to make or "activate" your Ayushman card, it is a fraud.
- **Only official channels exist:** beneficiary.nha.gov.in, the Ayushman app, the UMANG app, a CSC, or a hospital's Ayushman Mitra. Any other "portal" is not the government's.
- **Never share an OTP** with anyone who offers to "do it for you". The OTP is your signature.

If you spot a fraud, report it on 14555. Reporting protects the next family as much as your own.

PART FIVE

Using the cover well

20. From admission to discharge

Using the cover is a short, structured process. Knowing it in advance turns a stressful day into a routine one.

1. **Go to an empanelled hospital.** The card works only at hospitals on the PM-JAY list - check on the portal or ask at the desk.
2. **Show your Ayushman card and Aadhaar** at the help desk, and meet the Ayushman Mitra.
3. **The hospital verifies you** through eKYC and, for certain treatments, takes pre-authorisation from the state's approval team.
4. **Treatment begins.** For covered packages the care is cashless at the point of service - the hospital claims from the scheme, not from you.
5. **Discharge:** you should not be asked to pay for a covered package. Keep the discharge summary and papers.
6. **Follow-up:** up to 15 days of post-hospitalisation care and medicines are part of the same cover, so ask for them on the scheme.

If you are ever asked to pay cash for a covered treatment, do not simply pay and leave. Ask the Ayushman Mitra why, and note it - that is exactly the kind of case the grievance system is built for.

21. Treatment in another state

One of the scheme's best features is portability: the card works across India, not just in your home state.

You can walk into any empanelled public or private hospital anywhere in the country and get cashless treatment for covered packages. By 30 June 2026, more than 29.05 lakh inter-state admissions worth Rs. 8,383.97 crore had been authorised this way. The Ayushman Mitra at the hospital handles the coordination with your home state's approval team.

If you have migrated for work

Keep your card and Aadhaar with you. If you or your family fall ill far from home, you do not have to travel back - the nearest empanelled hospital can treat you on the same card.

22. Pre-authorisation and the Rs. 1 lakh safety valve

Some treatments need approval before they begin. Knowing this avoids a surprise at the counter.

Certain high-value or specific procedures require **pre-authorisation** - the hospital submits the case and the state approves it before treatment. This is normal and the hospital's job, not yours, but it is worth asking "does this need pre-authorisation?" so you understand the timeline.

There is also a provision for treatments that are not on the standard list. For a **surgical** procedure that is not a listed package, an "unspecified procedure" can be used, up to Rs. 1 lakh within your overall Rs. 5 lakh limit, subject to pre-authorisation and certain conditions. It is designed so that a beneficiary is not denied care simply because their exact surgery is not on a list.

23. The rest of Ayushman Bharat

PM-JAY is the famous part. The surrounding pieces are what make it work day to day - and most families never use them.

Service	What it does for you
Ayushman Arogya Mandirs	Free or low-cost primary care near your home: check-ups, common illnesses, screening for diabetes and blood pressure, and essential medicines. More than 1.86 lakh centres by 2026.
eSanjeevani	Free government telemedicine. Consult a doctor by video from an Arogya Mandir or from home when travel is hard.
ABHA health ID	A digital health account that links your medical records. Over 97.61 crore IDs existed by September 2026. It keeps your history in one place when you change hospitals.
Jan Aushadhi Kendras	Government-run pharmacies selling quality generic medicines at low prices - useful for the medicines PM-JAY does not cover, like long-term OPD prescriptions.

Used together, these four close most of the gaps that PM-JAY leaves: the clinic handles routine care, telemedicine handles distance, ABHA handles records, and Jan Aushadhi handles the medicine bill.

24. PM-JAY and your private insurance together

A common and reasonable question: if I already have a private health policy, does PM-JAY still help me?

For most people the honest answer is yes, in a specific way. PM-JAY is a government benefit, not a commercial policy, and holding private insurance does not disqualify you - the scheme explicitly allows people on private policies to use it. And for seniors aged 70 or above, private cover is irrelevant to eligibility: the Vay Vandana Card is universal.

Where it helps practically: PM-JAY covers a long list of hospital packages with no co-payment and no waiting period for pre-existing conditions. For a household with an elder and a modest private policy, using PM-JAY for a covered hospitalisation can preserve the private sum insured for treatments PM-JAY does not list.

The one rule to respect: you cannot claim reimbursement twice for the same expense. The two covers can complement each other across different treatments or years, but the same bill is paid once.

Because the details depend on your policy and the hospital, confirm the sequence with the hospital's Ayushman Mitra and your insurer before admission - not after.

PART SIX

Situations you will meet

25. Maternity, newborn and child care

For a young family, the hospital bill that matters most is often a delivery. PM-JAY's package list includes maternity and newborn care, so a delivery or a newborn's hospital care at an empanelled hospital can be covered.

Two things are worth separating here. The **hospital side** - the delivery, the stay, the newborn's care if the baby needs it - sits inside PM-JAY's hospitalisation packages. The **cash side** - money paid to the mother - comes from different schemes entirely. Pradhan Mantri Matru Vandana Yojana (PMMVY) gives a cash benefit for a first living child, and Janani Suraksha Yojana (JSY) supports institutional delivery. They are separate from the Ayushman card and are applied for separately.

Practically, this means: ask at the hospital's help desk whether the delivery package is covered under your state's list, keep the mother's Aadhaar and the family's Ayushman card together at admission, and ask the Ayushman Mitra about PMMVY and JSY before you leave. Many families claim the hospital cover and miss the cash benefit simply because nobody mentioned it.

Newborn care counts
If a newborn needs hospital care, that is a covered package - do not assume a baby is outside the scheme. Ask the hospital to bill it under PM-JAY.

26. The first sixty minutes of an emergency

In an emergency, the scheme bends toward the patient. Here is how to use that.

1. Get the patient to the nearest empanelled hospital, or call an ambulance service if you need transport. Life comes before paperwork.
2. Tell the front desk immediately that the patient is a PM-JAY beneficiary. Ask for the Ayushman Mitra.
3. Give the patient's Aadhaar and Ayushman card if you have them. If you do not, give the details and follow up.
4. In an emergency, an empanelled hospital should admit and begin treatment, with card verification completed within about 24 hours of admission. Ask them to note this.
5. Once the patient is stable, complete the eKYC and paperwork with the Ayushman Mitra.
6. Keep every paper you are given. The discharge summary and the admission record are your evidence if there is any dispute later.

The single most useful sentence you can say at a hospital counter is: "This is a PM-JAY case - please connect me to the Ayushman Mitra." That routes you to the one person whose job is to make the scheme work for you.

27. Other schemes to stack on top

PM-JAY does not stand alone. Several other government schemes fill the gaps it leaves, and they are cheap or free to join.

Scheme	What it gives you	Rough cost
PMSBY (accident cover)	Rs. 2 lakh for accidental death or disability	Rs. 20 a year
PMJJBY (life cover)	Rs. 2 lakh life cover	Rs. 436 a year
PMMVY	Cash benefit for a first living child	Free to apply
Janani Suraksha Yojana	Cash support for institutional delivery	Free to apply
Jan Aushadhi	Low-cost generic medicines for OPD prescriptions	Pay per medicine
e-Shram	Portable worker identity and welfare access	Free
Ration / ONORC	Ration portability across states	Free

These are separate schemes with their own rules, so confirm the current terms before relying on them. The point is simple: a family that uses PM-JAY plus a small accident and life cover plus Jan Aushadhi for everyday medicines is far better protected than one relying on any single scheme.

28. Finding and checking an empanelled hospital

Your card only works at an empanelled hospital, and empanelment can lapse. Thirty seconds of checking saves a wasted trip.

1. Search the hospital list on the PM-JAY portal or the public dashboard. You can filter by state and district.
2. Confirm the hospital is currently empanelled - not just that it was last year.
3. Check that the hospital offers the specialty you need. A hospital may be empanelled but not for every treatment.
4. For planned treatment, call ahead and ask whether your package needs pre-authorisation and how long it takes.
5. Save the Ayushman Mitra's number. It is the fastest line to a solution on the day.

By February 2026 there were more than 36,000 empanelled hospitals across India, about 19,500 of them public and 16,700 private. That breadth is the scheme's strength - but breadth also means the quality of the front desk varies, which is why knowing your rights matters.

29. Words hospitals use, decoded

Six words cause most of the confusion at a hospital counter. Learn them once.

Word	What it means for you
Empanelled	The hospital is authorised to treat PM-JAY patients. Only here does the card work.
Package	A fixed treatment with a fixed government rate. Covered packages are cashless for you.
Pre-authorisation	Advance approval for certain treatments. The hospital arranges it.
Cashless	You do not pay at the counter for a covered package. The hospital claims from the scheme.
Day-care	Treatment needing hospital facilities but no overnight stay, still covered.
Portability	Using your card at an empanelled hospital outside your home state.
Secondary / tertiary care	Specialist and advanced hospital care - the exact focus of this scheme.

If a hospital uses a word you do not understand, ask them to explain it. That is not a favour; it is part of their duty as an empanelled provider.

30. Eight myths, busted

These eight beliefs keep families from using cover they are entitled to.

- **"Only below-poverty-line families get it."** False. Everyone aged 70 and above qualifies regardless of income, and many state schemes are far broader than the central list.
- **"I need an income certificate to apply."** False. Eligibility is checked against government databases, not a fresh income certificate.
- **"It covers my doctor visits and medicines."** False. It is hospitalisation cover; primary care runs through Ayushman Arogya Mandirs.
- **"I have to pay at the hospital and claim later."** False. For covered packages, treatment is cashless at the point of service.
- **"It replaces my private insurance."** False, and the opposite can be true - the two can complement each other, so long as you never claim the same expense twice.
- **"There is a limit on how many family members are covered."** False. No cap on family size, age or gender.
- **"If my family is already covered, my elderly parent is not."** False. The 70-plus member gets a separate top-up cover of up to Rs. 5 lakh.
- **"I must go through an agent."** False, and often a fraud signal. The official channels are free and open to you directly.

31. Three families, three outcomes

These are illustrative examples built from the scheme's rules, not real people. They show how the same steps play out in different homes.

The household with an elder. A 74-year-old man lives with his son's family, who have a modest private policy. They assume their father is too "well-off" to qualify. Reading Chapter 6, they learn that age, not income, decides this door. They enrol him through the Ayushman app in one sitting and get a distinct Vay Vandana Card. Months later, a hip-replacement is billed to the scheme instead of draining the family's private cover.

The rejected applicant. A mother applies and is told she is "not eligible". Following Chapter 14, she checks eligibility again at the portal - still not found. The real cause, per Chapter 15, is a spelling difference between her Aadhaar and the household record. She corrects the Aadhaar at a UIDAI centre, returns to an Ayushman Mitra, and the card is generated the same week. No money changed hands.

The migrant worker. A family that moved cities for work fears a hospital bill far from their home state. Chapter 21 tells them the cover is portable: the nearest empanelled hospital treats them on the same card, and the Ayushman Mitra coordinates with the home state. What looked like a gap in the system turns out to be one of its best features.

PART SEVEN

Tools you will use

32. The master checklist

Print this. Tick every line. It is the fastest way to a working card.

1 Aadhaar name and date of birth read and understood.
2 Working mobile number linked to Aadhaar (checked).
3 Ration card / family ID located.
4 State, district and sub-scheme name noted.
5 Eligibility door identified (rural, urban occupation, 70-plus, special category, or state scheme).
6 For each senior aged 70 or above: Aadhaar ready, separate Vay Vandana card planned.
7 Application submitted online or at a CSC / Ayushman Mitra.
8 eKYC completed (OTP, fingerprint, iris or face).
9 Approval received (usually 24-48 hours).
10 Card downloaded as PDF and saved in the phone and in the cloud.
11 A printed copy kept in the house.
12 Every family member's card status checked and gaps filled.
13 Ayushman Mitra's contact and helpline 14555 saved in the phone.

33. The document kit

One folder, physical and digital, so a hospital visit never becomes a scramble.

Document	Why you need it
Aadhaar card (all members)	Identity and eKYC - the master document for the scheme
Ration card / family ID	Links the household to one wallet; speeds approval
Ayushman card (printed + PDF)	What you show at the hospital
Mobile with linked Aadhaar number	For OTPs at eKYC and at the hospital
Passport photo	Sometimes needed at enrolment
e-Shram / labour card (if any)	Supports eligibility for workers
Discharge summaries and bills	Your record; needed for follow-up and any grievance

Keep the digital copies in a shared cloud folder the whole family can reach, and one printed set in a plastic sleeve in the house.

34. The family readiness worksheet

Fill this in once, and your household is prepared for any hospital day.

Family member	Age	Card status	Action needed
		Generated / Pending / None	
		Generated / Pending / None	
		Generated / Pending / None	
		Generated / Pending / None	
		Generated / Pending / None	

Nearest empanelled hospital: _____

Ayushman Mitra contact: _____

Family helper who handles the paperwork: _____

35. The quick-reference card

The numbers and links worth memorising, or sticking on the fridge.

What	Where
Beneficiary portal (apply, eKYC, download)	beneficiary.nha.gov.in
Mobile apps	Ayushman app (Android) and UMANG
National helpline	14555 / 1800-111-565
Seniors' information line	missed call 1800110770
Grievance portal	cgrms.nha.gov.in
Scheme information	pmjay.gov.in and nha.gov.in
Cover amount	Rs. 5 lakh per family per year
Age rule for the universal card	70 and above, no income limit

36. Your 30-day family action plan

Doing this over a month, in small steps, is easier than doing it in a hospital corridor.

- **Week 1:** Complete the master checklist's first five lines. Check Aadhaar names and the linked mobile.

- **Week 2:** Apply for or download cards for every family member under 70. Fill the readiness worksheet.
- **Week 3:** Enrol every senior aged 70 or above for the Ayushman Vay Vandana Card.
- **Week 4:** Save the helpline, print the cards, build the document kit, and find your nearest empanelled hospital and Ayushman Arogya Mandir.

37. Twenty-five questions, answered

Short, direct answers to the questions families actually ask.

Question	Answer
Is the Ayushman card free?	Yes. There is no fee to apply, generate or correct it.
How much cover do I get?	Up to Rs. 5 lakh per family per year for hospitalisation, shared across the family.
Do I need an income certificate?	No. Eligibility is checked against government databases, not a new income certificate.
My parent is 72 and middle class. Are they eligible?	Yes. Everyone aged 70 and above qualifies regardless of income.
Does the 70-plus card share the family limit?	If the family is already covered, the senior gets a separate top-up. If not, the senior's cover is shared with the household.
What if the family is not in the database?	The 70-plus route or your state scheme may still cover you. Check both.
Can I use it outside my state?	Yes. Treatment is portable across India at empanelled hospitals.
Does it cover my existing illness?	Yes. Pre-existing conditions are covered from day one.
Does it cover my regular doctor visits?	No. That is primary care - use an Ayushman Arogya Mandir.
What is not covered?	OPD, dental, IVF, cosmetic surgery, routine vaccination, and a short list of other items.
How do I apply?	beneficiary.nha.gov.in, the Ayushman app, a CSC, or a hospital's Ayushman Mitra.
How long does approval take?	Often instant if details match; otherwise about 24-48 hours.
Why was I rejected?	Usually a database mismatch, a name or Aadhaar mismatch, or a technical eKYC failure.
How do I fix a name mismatch?	Correct the Aadhaar first, then re-apply. An Ayushman Mitra can help.
What if my fingerprint does not scan?	Use OTP or face authentication instead.
The hospital says my card will not work. Now what?	Verify empanelment, check the package, speak to the Ayushman Mitra, and call 14555 if wrongly refused.
Can a hospital refuse me?	No, not for a covered treatment if it is empanelled.
How do I complain?	Call 14555 or use cgrms.nha.gov.in. Resolution is committed within 30 days.

Question	Answer
Do I have to pay anything at the hospital?	No, for covered packages - the treatment is cashless.
Is there a family size limit?	No. No cap on family size, age or gender.
Can I have both PM-JAY and private insurance?	Yes, and it can help - but you cannot claim the same expense twice.
Do gig workers get this cover yet?	Registration is open on e-Shram, but the health cover itself had not been rolled out as of July 2026.
What is e-Shram for?	It gives platform and unorganised workers a Universal Account Number and access to welfare schemes.
What is the ABHA ID?	A digital health account that links your medical records across hospitals.
Where do I get medicines for long-term conditions?	Jan Aushadhi Kendras sell low-cost generic medicines for OPD prescriptions.

Appendix A: Your rights as a beneficiary

PM-JAY is an entitlement, not a favour. Knowing these rights turns a difficult conversation at a hospital counter into a short one.

- The right to be treated at any empanelled hospital for a covered package, in your home state or another.
- The right to cashless treatment - you should not be asked to pay for a covered package at the counter.
- The right to cover for pre-existing conditions from day one, with no waiting period.
- The right to cover with no limit on family size, age or gender.
- The right to a free card, and free corrections, re-verification and re-generation.
- The right to a reason if a hospital refuses, and to report a wrongful refusal on 14555.
- The right to help from the hospital's Ayushman Mitra.
- The right to file a grievance and to a response, with the NHA committing to resolution within 30 days.
- The right, for anyone aged 70 and above, to the Ayushman Vay Vandana Card regardless of income.

If a right is denied

Say it plainly, ask for the reason, ask for the Ayushman Mitra, and if it is still denied, call 14555. Rights that are never asserted are rights that quietly disappear.

Appendix B: ABHA and eSanjeevani, step by step

These two tools cost nothing and fix the two most annoying problems in Indian healthcare: lost records and long travel for a simple consultation.

ABHA - your digital health ID.

1. Go to the ABHA portal or download the ABHA app, or ask at an Ayushman Arogya Mandir or hospital counter.
2. Create your account using your Aadhaar number or a mobile number.
3. You receive an ABHA number and an ABHA address - your personal health account.
4. At each hospital, ask for your records to be linked to your ABHA. Over 97.61 crore IDs existed by September 2026.
5. Next time you change hospitals, your history travels with you instead of being retold from memory.

eSanjeevani - free government telemedicine.

1. Use the eSanjeevani service through your Ayushman Arogya Mandir, where a health worker can connect you to a doctor.
2. Or use the eSanjeevani app or web service to consult from home when travel is difficult.
3. Describe the problem, share your ABHA number if you have one, and follow the doctor's advice.
4. Use telemedicine for follow-ups, second opinions and non-emergencies - not for a genuine emergency, where you should go to a hospital.

Appendix C: A grievance that gets action

Most complaints fail not because they are wrong but because they are vague. A good grievance names the place, the date, the treatment, and what you want done.

Use the grievance portal at cgrms.nha.gov.in, or call 14555. Keep the reference number you are given. A short written complaint in this shape works:

Template you can copy

To: National Health Authority grievance portal (cgrms.nha.gov.in)
Subject: Wrongful refusal of PM-JAY treatment at [hospital name]

Beneficiary name: [name] | Ayushman card / PM-JAY ID: [number]
Hospital: [name, district, state] | Date of visit: [date]
What happened: I was [refused admission / asked to pay for a covered package / told my card was not accepted] for [treatment], although the hospital is empanelled and the treatment is a covered package.
What I want: [the treatment to be provided under PM-JAY / a refund of the amount wrongly charged / a written reason for the refusal].
Documents attached: card copy, hospital slip, any receipt.
Contact: [mobile number and email]

Send it, save the reference number, and diarise a follow-up for two weeks later. A dated, specific complaint is far harder to ignore than a phone call.

Appendix D: The one-page summary

If you read nothing else, read this. Photograph it and keep it in your phone.

Question	Answer
What is it?	Ayushman Bharat PM-JAY - up to Rs. 5 lakh a year for hospital treatment, paid cashless to the hospital.
Who is eligible?	Rural households on the 2011 deprivation list; urban households in 11 listed occupations; everyone aged 70 and above; special categories; and anyone covered by a merged state scheme.
The 70-plus rule?	Anyone 70 or older qualifies regardless of income, via the Ayushman Vay Vandana Card. Aadhaar is the only document needed.
How do I get it?	beneficiary.nha.gov.in, the Ayushman app, the UMANG app, a CSC, or a hospital's Ayushman Mitra.
What does it cost?	Nothing. No application fee, no correction fee, ever.
What is not covered?	OPD, dental, IVF, cosmetic surgery, routine vaccination and a short list of other items.
Does it work in another state?	Yes - the cover is portable across India at empanelled hospitals.
What if I am rejected?	Usually a database, name or eKYC issue. Fix the Aadhaar, visit an Ayushman Mitra, or complain at cgrms.nha.gov.in.
Key numbers	Helpline 14555 / 1800-111-565; seniors 1800110770; portal beneficiary.nha.gov.in.

Glossary

Term	Meaning
AB PM-JAY	Ayushman Bharat Pradhan Mantri Jan Arogya Yojana - the Rs. 5 lakh hospitalisation cover.
Ayushman card	The card that proves your PM-JAY entitlement.
Vay Vandana Card	The distinct card for every citizen aged 70 and above.
NHA	National Health Authority - the body that runs the scheme.
SHA	State Health Agency - runs the scheme in your state.
Ayushman Mitra / PMAM	The help-desk staff at an empanelled hospital who assist beneficiaries.
CSC	Common Service Centre - a local government service point.
eKYC	Electronic identity verification, usually through Aadhaar.
Empanelled hospital	A hospital authorised to treat PM-JAY beneficiaries.
Portability	Using your card at an empanelled hospital in another state.
Pre-authorisation	Advance approval for certain treatments before they begin.
ABHA	Ayushman Bharat Health Account - your digital health ID.
e-Shram	The government portal where unorganised and gig workers register.

Sources

Every figure and rule in this playbook is drawn from official or primary sources. Where a rule matters for a decision, confirm it at the portal or on 14555 before you act.

- National Health Authority - About PM-JAY (nha.gov.in/PM-JAY)
- PM-JAY beneficiary portal (beneficiary.nha.gov.in)
- Press Information Bureau - Ayushman Bharat eighth-anniversary release, 22 September 2026
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- NHA Health Benefit Package manual (HBP) - covered procedures and exclusions
- NHA beneficiary identification and eKYC user manual (BIS 2.0)
- Union Budget 2025-26 announcements on gig and platform workers; Ministry of Labour and Employment replies (2026)

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